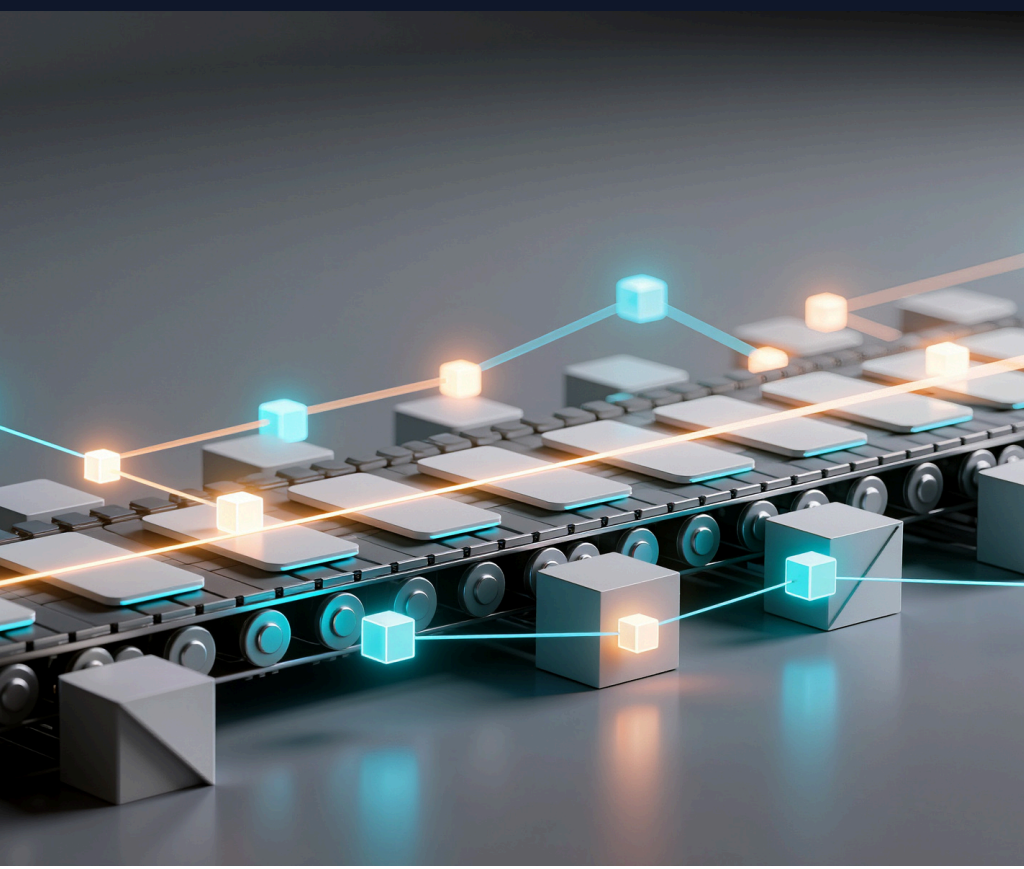
SKIP HIRE BROKERAGE AUTOMATION
CASE STUDY

Groundtech UK

FROM 17-MINUTE ORDERS AND MISSED CALLS TO A 4-MINUTE, FULLY-AUTOMATED WORKFLOW.



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WHATSAPP:

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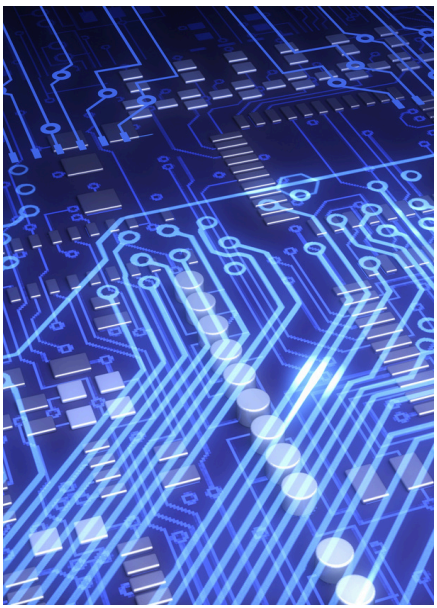
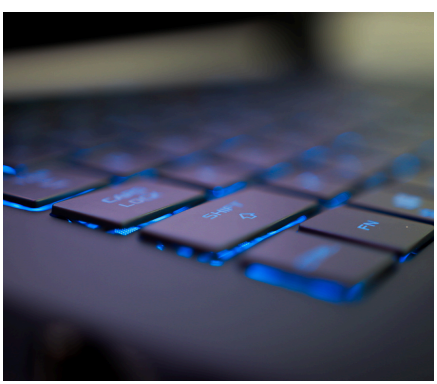
INTRODUCTION

ETA DIGITAL

ETA Digital is a UK-based digital marketing agency specialising in helping small and medium-sized businesses strengthen their online presence and generate leads. The agency delivers tailored digital solutions, including website design, search engine optimisation (SEO), and lead generation strategies, with a strong focus on measurable results.

By combining technical expertise with user-focused design and strategic planning, ETA Digital works to improve search visibility and convert website traffic into customer enquiries. The agency positions itself as a long-term digital partner, supporting sustainable growth through ongoing optimisation and performance-driven digital marketing.





ETA Digital believes in building digital strategies that are transparent, tailored, and results-driven. The company places strong emphasis on long-term partnerships, focusing on sustainable growth, clear communication, and delivering measurable value for its clients.

CHAPTER I

The Problem

Groundtech UK's skip hire brokerage team were drowning in manual admin every time the phone rang.

Processing a single order took on average:

- **7 minutes** on the phone with the customer
- **10+ minutes** after the call to actually process the order

Total: **17 minutes per order.**

On the phone (7+ minutes of chaos)
While on the phone to a customer, staff had to:

- Pull prices from 50+ different spreadsheets (one for each supplier)
- Use an educated guess on which suppliers covered the customer's postcode, then open the "right" sheet
- Find the correct skip size + postcode on the sheet to see the supplier's cost
- Manually work out a sell price on the spot based on that cost
- Open a separate spreadsheet to check if a council permit was needed for that postcode, then manually add a margin and include it in the quote
- If the customer needed extras (e.g. mattress, electrical items), jump to yet another spreadsheet, look up the cost, mentally add a margin, and quote
- Take down all customer details by hand so the order could be processed later

Every quote required juggling multiple spreadsheets, mental maths, and manual lookups — all while the customer waited on the phone.

After the call (10+ minutes of manual processing)
Once they'd finally got off the phone, the real admin started. For every order, staff had to:

- Manually fill in customer details into a purchase order form
- Email the purchase order to the supplier and wait for acknowledgement
- If the supplier didn't respond within a few hours, staff had to phone and chase, eating more time
- Re-type customer details again onto a customer invoice and email it out
- Print both the purchase order and invoice and physically file them for the accounts team

On top of this ...

They had a tracking problem:
Groundtech were receiving calls from **100+ different lead sources** (Yell, Facebook, Checkatrade, etc.) but:

- They could only see **total orders** per area
- They couldn't see **total leads**, conversion rates, or revenue by lead source

This made it almost impossible to scale spend intelligently, because they didn't know which lead sources were actually working and which were wasting money

CHAPTER II

Impact on the Business

The operational impact was brutal.

Time and Capacity

17 minutes per order meant staff simply couldn't keep up with inbound calls

- While processing orders, staff **couldn't answer new calls** — phones were literally turned off to "catch up" on admin
- Sometimes staff tried to take **3–4 orders in a row**, then process them all afterwards, which:
  - Didn't reduce total time per order
  - **Increased errors** due to volume and mental fatigue

This directly cost the company money through:

- **Missed calls = missed orders**
- Longer wait times and slower service

Offhire inefficiency

When customers rang to have a skip collected (offhire):

- Staff had to **call the supplier** and request collection – up to 5 minutes depending on hold times
- Or email the supplier, which still took ~2 minutes

Multiply that by the number of offhires per day and it was another quiet drain on time and focus.

Errors and Wasted Journeys

The manual nature of the process meant:

- Wrong delivery addresses
- Incorrect customer contact details
- Incorrect pricing on orders (either costing margin or causing friction with customers)

Mixed-up PO vs invoice totals (buy vs sell price) All of these led to:

- **Wasted journeys** for suppliers
- Skips not being delivered on time
- Customers not getting the service they paid for

And because staff were juggling so many details manually, they often:

- Forgot to chase suppliers who hadn't confirmed the order
- Result: **customers sometimes didn't get their skip at all**

No visibility on marketing ROI

Because there was no proper lead tracking:

- They didn't know total leads per source
- They couldn't see conversion rates by source
- They had no clear picture of which channels were profitable vs which to cut

So marketing budget allocation was basically guesswork.

CHAPTER III

The Solution

We implemented a **custom-built CRM** specifically for Groundtech UK's skip hire brokerage.

The goal: **Automate almost the entire order lifecycle** so staff could:

- Spend less time hunting for information
- Stop re-typing the same data three times
- Remove post-call processing entirely
- Track leads, orders, and performance in one place
- Scale revenue without increasing headcount

At a high level, the system included...

- A **central supplier & pricing database** linked to postcodes and skip sizes
- A clear **red "sell price"** for each option (stopping pricing errors on the phone)
- Built-in **permit and extras pricing** logic
- A guided, **step-by-step order journey** with required fields so nothing could be missed
- Integrated **payment processing**
- Automatic **purchase order and invoice generation + emailing**
- **Direct QuickBooks** integration so accounts got clean, structured data with zero manual input
- A full **order history** with statuses and notes
- One-click **offhire and exchange** functionality
- **Lead source tracking and conversion reporting**
- **User logins and permissions** so managers could see reports, revenue, profit, and performance by lead source and staff member

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The effect:

Order processing time after the call dropped to **0 minutes,** and the average time on the phone dropped from **7 minutes to 4.**

CHAPTER IV

Implementation

We designed the CRM to mirror Groundtech's real-world workflow, but with all the friction removed.

1. Centralised pricing & supplier coverage

1. We built a:

- **Supplier & postcode database:**
  - Staff can now enter a customer's postcode and instantly see **all suppliers who cover that area**
  - For each supplier and skip size, they see:
    - Supplier cost
    - A clearly highlighted **red sell price** (editable if needed)

This removed the need to remember which supplier covers which area or dig through 50 spreadsheets. Price lookups went from **1–2 minutes to ~5 seconds.**

We also stored:

- **Permit costs** by postcode/supplier
- **Additional item costs** (e.g. mattresses, electrical items)

So staff could add these on with a click instead of digging through separate spreadsheets and doing mental maths.

2. Lead source tracking

When entering a postcode, staff now select a **lead source** from a dropdown.

- The system:
- Stores the lead source against the order
- Tracks whether each lead **converted to a sale or not**

This laid the groundwork for:

- Clear **total leads per source**
- **Conversion rates** per source
- Revenue and profit by source

So Groundtech could finally see where marketing spend was working

3. Guided order capture & payment in one place

We built an intuitive, **step-by-step order flow:**

- Customer details page (including special delivery instructions)
- Skip size, supplier, permits, extras
- Built-in **payment processing**, so staff take payment inside the CRM without opening extra tabs

The system requires all critical fields before moving on, which:

- Prevents missing information
- Stops the need to call customers back to fill in gaps
- Reduces mental load for staff

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4. Automated paperwork & accounting

Once an order is completed:

- The system **automatically generates:**
  - A **purchase order** to the supplier
  - A **customer invoice**

Both:

- Are emailed instantly to supplier and customer
- Are sent from the **professional company email** of the staff member logged in

At the same time:

- All order details are automatically sent to **QuickBooks**
- Data is mapped into the correct fields for the accounts team

No more:

- Writing customer details **three times**
- Manually filling and emailing POs and invoices
- Accounts spending **two days a week** typing orders

5. Order status tracking & supplier confirmations

We added live **order statuses** and smart email links:

- When a supplier receives a PO, they can **click a link** to confirm
- The order status auto-updates from **"Paid" to "Confirmed by supplier"** in the CRM

At a glance, staff can:

- See which orders are still **unconfirmed (amber)**
- Only chase the ones that actually need a follow-up at the end of the day

Statuses can also be changed manually if needed.

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6. One-click offhire & customer reviews

When a customer wants their skip collected:

- Staff quickly **search by postcode**
- Click a **single offhire button**

This triggers:

- An email to the supplier with all relevant order details, asking for collection
- An email to the customer confirming the **collection request**

The order status changes to **"Collection requested" (amber)** and turns **green** when the supplier clicks to confirm via email.

At the offhire stage:

- The system **prompts staff to ask for feedback**
- If the customer gives positive feedback, staff click **Yes,** and:
  - The customer is emailed a **review link** for the exact lead source they originally came through (Facebook, Yell, Checkatrade, etc.)

This solved two problems:

- Staff previously **forgot to ask for reviews**
- It was impossible to remember which lead source the customer originally came from weeks later

Now the system just handles it.

7. Fast exchanges & complete order history

For exchanges (customer swaps a full skip for an empty one):

- Staff click an Exchange button on the original order
- A new order is created with all details auto-populated:
  - Customer info
  - Skip size
  - Agreed sell price (even if manually adjusted from the default)

Details can be edited if needed, but:

- Staff don't have to re-capture everything
- Customers don't have to repeat their details

Every order is stored in **Order History**, including:

- Full order details
- Time and date
- Who processed it
- Notes
- Payment info
- Status
- Buttons to re-send PO/invoice emails or download documents

Finding an old order is now instant, instead of digging through paper files

8. User logins, permissions & reporting

We set up individual logins for all staff with appropriate access levels:

- **All staff** can:
  - Add suppliers
  - Adjust pricing
  - Add extras
  - Add/remove lead sources and review links
  - Process new orders
  - View order history
- **Managers** get access to:
  - Revenue and profit reports
  - Lead source performance and **conversion data**
  - Conversion rates per **staff member**
  - User access controls (add/remove staff and permissions)

This turned the system from a simple workflow tool into a proper **ops and performance dashboard.**

CHAPTER IV

Results

The impact was both operational and financial.

Time and Capacity

- **Post-call processing time** per order:
  - From **10+ minutes → 0 minutes**
- **Average time on the phone:**
  - From **7 minutes → ~4 minutes**

Total handling time per order:

- From **17 minutes → 4 minutes**

That's a **4x increase in capacity per staff member** for handling orders, without hiring anyone new

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Revenue & answered leads

With the combination of:

- Faster order handling
- Automation freeing staff to answer more calls
- Automated review requests boosting inbound demand

Groundtech saw:

- **Monthly revenue increase**:
  - From **£90k in June → £173k in September**
- **Total answered leads per month**:
  - From **4,152 in June → 5,327 in September**

Crucially, this was achieved with:

- **No additional marketing spend**
- Just **better allocation of existing spend** thanks to the new lead source data

The review automation and prompts:

- **Tripled the number of reviews** on key lead sources

Increased the volume of inbound calls organically

Operational efficiency & error reduction

Key improvements:

- Price lookup time:
  - From **1–2 minutes → ~5 seconds**
- No need to remember supplier coverage by postcode
- No more writing customer details **three times**
- Dramatically fewer:
  - Wrong addresses
  - Incorrect contact details
  - Pricing errors on invoices vs POs

The accounts team:

- Went from **two days per week keying data into software → 0 time**, as everything now lands in QuickBooks automatically and correctly mapped.
- Offhire & supplier chasing:
- Offhire request time:
  - From **~2–5 minutes → ~20 seconds**
- Staff chase only the **unconfirmed amber statuses** at the end of the day instead of blindly following up everything.

Strategic clarity

With the new CRM and tracking:

- Groundtech now know for each **lead source**:
  - Total leads
  - Total sales
  - Conversion rates

This allows them to:

- Double down on what works
- Reduce or cut budget from underperforming sources
- Confidently plan further growth